

LECHAUSTRIAEDIT

This week I'm in the Lech area of the Aalburg in Austria, and I'm very honoured to be speaking with Professor Hubert Schwetzler, who is one of the Lech locals here and has been around Lech for a very long time, and indeed they call you Mr Lech. Thank you, that was my nickname, yeah, all my life, because I was Director of Tourism for 40 years in Lech, and I saw all the changes from the beginning to an international ski resort, which of course was a very interesting time. Yes, and it's such a beautiful place, and it's right in the middle of the Aalburg region where you have Lech, Oberlech, Zürs, Stubben, Christoph and St Anton, and from the Lech area you can really get around easily, can't you? Yeah, better than ever, because since two years Lech ski area is connected with Ward at the end of the Bregenzerwald, with many interesting slopes, especially in springtime, because it's not so sunny, and therefore the snow is good in spring, and next year there will be a connection between Zürs and Alpe Rauz, in other words that means that the entire Aalburg will be connected, and it will be the largest ski resort in Austria after that.

Now tell us a bit about the beautiful hotel that we're sitting in, I believe it's your family hotel, and it's right at the bottom of the slope in Lech, you can step out onto the snow. Maybe one of the reasons why I'm still in Lech was that I met at the very beginning a Lech girl, and we are married now since 50 years, and from her parents she got a piece of land, so we built the Haldenhof, but that was the business of my wife, because I was traveling around the world to make Lech popular, and she was the host and the soul of the house, which is now handed over to the second generation, to our son Michael and his nice wife Claudia, and they also have two kids, and they join a hotel training school, so I think the third generation is already in safe hands. Such a beautiful Austrian themed hotel right in the middle of Lech, and you couldn't get any better if you're looking for somewhere to stay, this is the place.

And speaking of your travels around the world, Hubert, you actually were instrumental in organizing a lot of the Austrian ski instructors to head down to Australia and New Zealand in the past. I came to Lech in 1961 for one winter season to open up a travel agency, and as I mentioned I'm still here, but at the beginning I remember that January was not going very fast. After the 6th of January there was a big gap, because there are no school holidays in Europe, so I realized that in the southern hemisphere they have their long holidays, so I thought we must try to get the connection, and as many of the Australian, New Zealand and South American ski schools were founded by guys from Austria, there still was a connection, and at the Zinit there were more than 80 ski instructors, mainly from the Zur Ski School, after our season, going by boat first, and then later on of course by air, to the overseas ski resorts to teach there, and so I realized that would be a chance to get rid of this January gap, and it worked.

We had a wonderful ski today, and you took me around as your guide out of Lech, now can you describe for our listeners how we exactly started and what we did today? As we did not have the brightest day, and a little bit fog on the top, we did the lower bit, and we started the south side of

Lech, this is our largest ski area south facing, so we went up Schlegelkopf chairlift right from the center, then we continued to the Kriegerhorn, we skied down first time to Hasensprung and did a few runs on the on the medium heights, and then it cleared up, so we went around and went up the Steinheder, and there a big snowstorm received us to say hello from deep winter, but after that, fighting through, we came down and skied some runs near the woods, because the visibility was better there, and then we ended up in Oberlech for a nice lunch at Patrick Ortlieb's, one of our Olympic Champions Hotel Montana in Oberlech, for lunch, and then we skied down here and had a quick look through the village, what we have not seen is the other side of Lech, which is the Rüfikopf area, you would go up with the cable car, and then the main, there is a wonderful top secret run, a steep one behind called the Lange Zug, something for very good skiers, but the main runs go over to Zürs, with the tea bar and the chairlift you end up in Zürs, and then the famous ring would go up from Zürs to Seekopf, Madloch, from Madloch you would ski down to Zug, from Zug again with the Zuger Bergbahn to the Kriegerhorn, that's where we were, and then you have done the other thing, may I just tell you a few things for the older skiers to remember, skiing structures, before they started, they had to prepare the slopes for the beginners by foot, you know, then I remember that the first lifts were tea bars, then I remember when the first one-man chairlift was introduced, with the capacity of about 250 to the Kriegerhorn and to the Madloch, little gondolas came, and when you see the change in techniques there, also skiing equipment, you had the two meter 30 skis to go fast downhill, which you could not manage anymore, piece preparation, the first machines coming, snowmaking, all this, and also the knowledge of skiers, I can give you with one example, we have every year a race called the Weiße Ring, the White Ring, it starts on the Rüfikopf in Lech, goes to Zürs, over Zug and back, including lifts, Patrick Ortlieb still has the record, it's under three quarters of an hour, and when I came to Lech 1961, still to go up with the Rüfikopf, to ski over to Zürs, there was nothing in between, there are two extra lifts now, there was nothing, to Zürs, then up the Kriegerhorn and back to Lech, was about today, not the Kriegerhorn, direct to Lech, was about today, a program of a skier, so you can see technique and also the art of skiing, the knowledge has changed quite a bit. Well, it's been a pleasure having you on the program this week, my guest Professor Hubert Schwertzler, here at the beautiful Heidenhof Hotel, right in the middle of Lech, and thank you very much for being with us on the program. Oh, it was a pleasure to meet you, and I must give you a compliment, even when the visibility was not bright, and you wear glasses, you were a great skier.

Well, that's coming from you, Hubert, that's a huge compliment, thank you very much, and how we say in Austrian, we say Tschüss for see you later. Servus. Servus, yes, that's nice, it's a typical Austrian, servus and see you, wish you were here, and hopefully we see you on our slopes.